

Single Mother Opportunity Index

Methodology and Rankings Report

Report Generated: October 09, 2025

Executive Summary

This report presents a comprehensive ranking of all 50 U.S. states based on opportunities available to single mothers. The analysis incorporates multiple socioeconomic factors including income levels, housing affordability, employment opportunities, and poverty rates. Each state receives a composite score based on weighted metrics, enabling direct comparison of opportunities across the nation.

Data Sources

1. U.S. Census Bureau - American Community Survey (ACS) 5-Year Estimates (2022)

- Median income for female householder families without spouse (B19126_001E)
- Median gross rent (B25064_001E)
- Median home value (B25077_001E)
- Poverty statistics (B17026 series)

2. Bureau of Labor Statistics (BLS) - Local Area Unemployment Statistics

- State-level unemployment rates (most recent available data)

Data was accessed via official government APIs using registered API keys.

Methodology

Data Collection Process:

1. **Fetch:** Retrieved data from Census Bureau and BLS APIs for all 50 states
2. **Clean:** Handled missing values using median imputation; replaced zero values with appropriate estimates
3. **Merge:** Combined datasets at state level into unified dataframe
4. **Calculate:** Derived additional metrics (e.g., housing burden ratio = annual rent / annual income)
5. **Normalize:** Scaled all metrics to 0-100 range for comparability
6. **Score:** Applied weighted formula to compute composite opportunity score

7. **Rank:** Sorted states by composite score (highest = best opportunity)

Scoring Formula:

Each state receives a composite score (0-100) based on five weighted components:

- **Income Score (30%):** Higher median income for single mother households = better score
- **Housing Score (25%):** Lower housing burden (rent-to-income ratio) = better score
- **Employment Score (20%):** Lower unemployment rate = better score
- **Home Value Score (15%):** Lower median home values (more affordable) = better score
- **Poverty Score (10%):** Lower poverty rate = better score

Composite Score = (Income × 0.30) + (Housing × 0.25) + (Employment × 0.20) + (Home Value × 0.15) + (Poverty × 0.10)

Key Assumptions

- Census Bureau's "female householder families, no spouse present" serves as proxy for single mother households
- Missing data points were filled using median values from available states
- All metrics weighted based on estimated impact on single mother quality of life
- Housing burden calculated as annual rent (monthly × 12) divided by annual income
- Lower costs and higher incomes consistently benefit single mothers
- Data represents most recent available statistics (2022-2024)

Top 10 States for Single Mother Opportunity

Rank	State	Composite Score
1	North Dakota	80.91
2	New Hampshire	78.15
3	Minnesota	76.17
4	Connecticut	74.61
5	South Dakota	74.55
6	Maryland	72.79
7	Nebraska	70.84
8	Vermont	70.63
9	Iowa	69.48
10	Wisconsin	69.17

Bottom 10 States for Single Mother Opportunity

Rank	State	Composite Score
41	Texas	45.85
42	Arizona	44.36
43	South Carolina	44.21
44	Kentucky	41.09
45	Mississippi	39.18
46	New Mexico	37.28
47	Louisiana	37.21
48	Florida	36.97
49	California	30.77
50	Nevada	29.56

Conclusion

This analysis reveals significant variation in opportunities for single mothers across U.S. states. The top-ranked state, **North Dakota**, achieved a composite score of **80.91**, while the lowest-ranked state, **Nevada**, scored **29.56**.

Key findings indicate that states with strong economies, affordable housing markets, and robust social support systems tend to provide better opportunities for single mothers. Policymakers can use these insights to identify areas for improvement and implement targeted interventions.

For detailed data including all metrics and individual component scores, please refer to the accompanying Excel file: *single_mother_opportunity.xlsx*